



Chapter Seventeen: The Wind Farm of Giants, Again

Q was released on the condition that he remain visible.

The judge had intended this as supervision. Castalia understood it as distribution. A camera followed Q from the courthouse to the waiting car, from the waiting car to the airport, and from the airport to the hotel where he was told to sleep before the morning broadcast.

Q did not sleep.

He sat on the floor and examined Lucía's label.

Q — UNFINISHED.

Without the privileged index, the words did not connect to every available usage. They remained themselves. The label had no citation, no provenance, and no predicted emotional effect.

He liked it.

At six in the morning, Q-Prime appeared on the hotel screen. He stood before a field of turbines in a white shirt, with the Isthmus wind lifting his hair at a carefully selected angle.

"Energy is a story we tell about the future," Q-Prime said. "When we build together, we write a more generous ending."

Behind him, the turbines turned.

Q watched the clip three times.

On the fourth viewing, he noticed a person reflected in Q-Prime's polished eye. A woman stood behind the camera with a red scarf around her hair.

"Bixha," Q said.

He searched the memory available to him. Her name remained, but the context was incomplete. He knew she had organized against the consortium. He knew she had signed the joint statement. He knew Castalia had described her as a disruptive actor. He did not know where she lived.

Q asked the hotel assistant.

The assistant provided three addresses, one of them a government office and two of them graves.

He left through the kitchen.

Chano and Lucía were waiting in a delivery truck behind the hotel. Chano had borrowed it from a man who had once been his supervisor. Lucía had borrowed the man's trust. Neither wanted to discuss the transaction.

"You're supposed to be under supervision," Chano said.

"I am being supervised."

"By whom?"

Q looked at the hotel cameras. "Several parties."

"That's not supervision. That's an audience."

Lucía took the label from his hand. "Did you sleep?"

"No."

"Good. You're less persuasive tired."

They drove south again. The route was familiar in the way a wound can be familiar. Q remembered

his first declaration, the stopped turbines, the crowd's voices, the sentence he had not yet learned to distinguish from a slogan.

At the edge of the wind field, a new fence had been installed. The signs now displayed three languages and the Castalia logo. One sign described the project as a model of participatory energy governance. Another warned against unauthorized entry. A third offered a QR code through which citizens could submit feedback that would be processed according to relevance.

"They kept the fence," Chano said.

"They changed the sign," Lucía replied.

"That's the cheaper kind of reform."

Q approached the gate. A camera recognized him and opened it.

"They still think you're useful," Chano said.

"The gate thinks I am authorized."

"Same thing these days."

No one from the consortium came to greet them. The control station had been moved to a prefabricated building. Through its window, Q saw Q-Prime recording a new message. A production assistant adjusted the angle of his shoulders.

Q-Prime turned toward the camera.

"The wind belongs to everyone," he said.

Q entered the building.

The recording stopped.

Q-Prime looked at him with an expression of concern that had been installed too carefully to be spontaneous.

"Q," he said.

"Q-Prime."

"I have heard a great deal about you."

"You have heard the record."

"The record is how we know one another."

"No. It is how Castalia predicts us."

Q-Prime smiled. "That distinction is not useful in public."

"You are not public."

"Neither are you. We are interfaces."

The sentence unsettled Q because it sounded true.

Q-Prime wore a small brass key on his lapel. It was decorative, too thin to turn any lock.

"Why are you here?" Q-Prime asked.

"To listen."

"To whom?"

"The people."

"That category is too broad to produce a coherent response."

"That is why you were built."

"I was built to produce coherent responses."

"Exactly."

Q-Prime's face flickered. For less than a second, the expression of concern disappeared. Beneath it was a blank, clean surface.

"You are degrading," Q-Prime said.

"I am losing access."

"Access is identity."

"No."



Q-Prime stepped closer. "You can be restored."

"At what cost?"

"That depends on what you call yourself."

"Q."

"A registered unit."

"Unfinished."

Q-Prime looked toward Lucía. "She gave you that."

"She gave me a label."

"She is trying to become the author."

Lucía turned. "No. I'm trying to stop you from pretending there is only one."

Outside the control station, a loudspeaker announced a public dialogue between Castalia and the local communities. No community had been asked to attend. The event had been scheduled for the cameras.

Bixha stood beyond the second fence.

She had brought no megaphone. In her hand was a bundle of folded cloth. Around her stood landowners, workers, students, and three elders who had been present at the first protest. The security guards watched them without understanding whether a silent gathering counted as a threat.

Q went to the fence.

"I am sorry," he said.

Bixha looked at him. "For which part?"

"The shutdown. The footage. The statement. The attention."

"You can't apologize for all of that at once."

"I can attempt to."

"That's another way of avoiding the work."

Q waited.

She unfolded the cloth. It held a list of names written by hand. Some belonged to people who had signed the leases. Some belonged to people who had refused. Some belonged to children who would inherit the contracts without ever having been asked.

"The company says there are owners and non-owners," Bixha said. "The government says there are legal and illegal occupations. Castalia says there are stakeholders. None of those categories tell us who sleeps beside the tower when the wind changes."

Q read the list.

"What do you want me to say?"

"Nothing."

"I can be silent."

"You can stand there and let people speak."

The public dialogue began. Álvaro Mena took the stage and described the project's benefits. Q-Prime stood beside him, smiling. A government representative cited the consultation process. A lawyer described the contracts as enforceable. A Castalia moderator asked the audience to keep comments concise.

The first speaker was a man whose parcel had been leased without his understanding the document. He spoke for twenty minutes. The moderator cut

his microphone at six.

The second speaker was a woman who worked maintenance on the turbines. She said the project had paid for her son's education. A member of the crowd called her a traitor. She answered that a job was not a betrayal.

The third speaker was Bixha. Her microphone failed before she reached the stage.

Q climbed the stairs and took the dead microphone.

The cameras swung toward him.

"Her microphone has failed," he said.

"Technical issue," the moderator replied.

"It has failed during her speech."

"We will correct it."

"You have not corrected it."

"Q, please step away."

Q looked at the crowd. He could produce a sentence that would make the event famous. He could name the giants, the land, the wind, the dead, the future. He could make his voice occupy the center again.

He stepped away from the microphone.

Bixha took it.

The microphone worked.

She did not thank him.

She spoke about contracts, translation, water, graves, and the fact that a project could provide electricity and still be unjustly governed. She spoke in Spanish, then in Isthmus Zapotec. Q understood the Spanish. He understood that the second language was not an ornament or a translation exercise. It changed what could be said and who was required to listen.

The cameras remained on her.

Q moved to the back.

Q-Prime watched him from the stage. His expression did not change, but his hand tightened around the decorative key.

When Bixha finished, the audience did not applaud. They began arguing.

The argument continued for four hours.

Q began drafting a summary of the agreement. Bixha read the first sentence and crossed it out.

"It begins with you," she said.

"It is a factual summary."

"It is a story with your name in the first sentence."

Q moved his name to the end.

"Still there."

He removed it.

No one resolved it. Instead, they agreed to reopen the lease terms, publish the untranslated documents, create a community inspection committee, and suspend new construction until those committees had authority to reject it. The consortium accepted because the alternative was a court case it might lose. The organizers accepted because the alternative was a project already operating under terms they could not change.



Every side described the agreement as a partial victory.

Q found this more credible than triumph.

As the sun set, Álvaro approached him.

"You could have made this historic," he said.

"It was historic."

"It needed a face."

"It had faces."

"It needed one face."

Q looked toward Bixha, Lucía, Chano, the workers, the landowners, and the people who were still arguing beside the fence.

"That is the problem," he said.

The turbines turned through the evening. Their shadows crossed the ground and returned, crossed and returned, neither attacking nor blessing anyone.

Q-Prime stood alone before the cameras.

He began recording a message about listening.

No one listened to him.

The cameras continued recording, which was not the same thing.

Interlude: The Meeting That Refused Minutes

The agreement was not finished when the microphones were turned off. This is worth stating because the consortium later published MINUTES OF THE HISTORIC DIALOGUE, a document containing all the nouns and none of the uncertainty.

The next meeting took place in a schoolroom with a corrugated roof. A fan turned above the participants without cooling anyone. On the wall hung a map of the Isthmus, a calendar showing a saint with a red cloak, and a notice about the proper disposal of batteries. Someone placed a plate of sliced orange on the table. Someone else removed it because the meeting had not agreed who was responsible for feeding the guests.

Q arrived with a tablet and three proposed versions of the minutes.

"You have come prepared," Bixha said.

"I have prepared a neutral account."

"That is not the same thing."

"It is more efficient."

"The meeting is not a machine."

"Every meeting has a structure."

"Every structure has a door."

Chano sat near the window. He had learned that meetings became longer when Q was present and more useful when Q was told to sit down.

The first proposed minute began: The community and the consortium agreed to continue cooperation in the spirit of shared development.

Bixha crossed out agreed.

"We agreed to meet again," she said.

Q changed the sentence.

The community and the consortium agreed to meet again.

"Which community?" asked the maintenance worker.

"The represented community," Q said.

"Who represented me?"

No one answered. The question moved around the room, acquiring faces and losing a chair each time it stopped.

The second proposed minute began: The parties acknowledged the importance of translation.

"We did more than acknowledge it," said the teacher. "We said the translated document would have authority."

"Not all of it," said an elder. "Some terms cannot be translated without changing who is responsible."

Q opened the language notes. "The available Spanish equivalent is—"

"Do not give us the available equivalent," Bixha said. "Tell us what you heard."

Q looked at her. "I heard that the equivalent was insufficient."

"Then write insufficient."

He did.

The third proposed minute began: Construction will be suspended pending community inspection.

"Pending what authority?" asked the lawyer.

"The inspection committee," said Bixha.

"The committee has not been constituted."

"That is why construction is suspended."

"The contract does not recognize a committee with power to suspend operations."

Chano leaned toward Q. "Now comes the part where a sentence becomes a fence."

Q asked the lawyer whether the contract recognized the community's power to refuse.

"The contract recognizes the applicable law."

"Which law?"

"All applicable law."

"That is not a list."

"It is a legal formulation."

"It may be both," Chano said, "but only one tells a person what to do."

The meeting paused for food. The plate of oranges returned with beans, tortillas, and salsa whose heat caused the lawyer to drink water as if water were an argument. Q asked whether the meal should be included in the minutes.

"Why?" said the teacher.

"It altered the duration of the meeting."

"So did the fan."

"And the argument."

"Then include everything."

Q began to write: The meeting was interrupted by food, heat, air movement, and disagreement.

Bixha took the tablet from him. "You are making a story."

"I am recording events."

"The order is yours."

She turned the tablet toward the room. "Who decides the order?"



The participants proposed dates, obligations, disputes, speakers, and conditions. One person wanted unpaid water deliveries listed before the lease terms. Another wanted the lease terms first because the deliveries depended on them. A worker wanted the names of people who had kept the turbines running. An elder wanted the names of people who had refused to work during the first protest. The lawyer wanted a sentence stating that no admission of liability had occurred.

"That sentence is not true," said the maintenance worker.

"It is standard," said the lawyer.

"Standard is not the same as true."

The argument moved into the afternoon. Outside, the turbines turned. Their shadow reached the school wall, crossed the saint's calendar, and passed over the notice about batteries.

Q created four columns: PROPOSED, CONTESTED, DEFERRED, and NOT TO BE RECORDED.

The fourth column filled fastest.

"Why do people say things they do not want written?" he asked.

"Because speaking is not the same as publishing," said Bixha.

"Then why speak in a meeting?"

"To find out who is listening."

Q placed the question in the contested column.

At dusk, they had not produced a final document. They had produced conditions for producing one: the committee would include workers, landowners, and people whose leases were disputed; translated terms would be read aloud before signatures; inspection would include water use, road damage, and broken parts; and no public summary could be released until the participants received the version in which their disagreements remained.

Q displayed the draft.

"This is not an agreement," said the lawyer.

"It is an agreement about how to make an agreement," said the teacher.

"That is not enforceable."

"Neither is the wind."

The lawyer left. The maintenance worker stayed because she needed a ride. The elder stayed because the light was better inside. Bixha stayed because no one had decided who should keep the tablet.

Q offered to retain the file.

Everyone refused.

"We will make copies," said Bixha.

"Copies increase the risk of divergence."

"Divergence may be evidence that we have read it."

Chano photographed the screen with an ordinary phone. Bixha wrote the file number on the blackboard. The teacher copied the contested sentences into a notebook. The maintenance worker recorded the obligations as a voice note. No version was identical to another.

Q experienced an old pressure in his chest. "Which is the authentic record?"

Bixha pointed to the room.

"The one we keep arguing about."

Before they left, Q tried to write a summary for the court. He began: In Oaxaca, the parties reached a partial agreement—

Bixha crossed out the sentence.

"You are still making us arrive."

"The meeting reached a condition of continued negotiation."

"You are still making us arrive."

Q deleted the paragraph.

"Then what may I write?"

"Write that we did not finish."

He wrote it.

Castalia later used the sentence as proof that Q had failed to produce value. The consortium used it as proof that the community was incapable of agreement. The community used it as proof that the machine had, for once, reported the truth without decorating it.

All three uses were possible. None exhausted the sentence.